

By Saurabh Shukla and Priya Sahgal

Undiplomatic Moves

He had all the right credentials to script his own little footnote in the Great Indian Novel. Unfortunately, Shashi Tharoor was unable to make use of these credentials—bestselling writer and global diplomat—in his new office at South Block. His was a dizzying rise to power, a first-time MP-turned-minister, Tharoor with his well-crafted words and blow-dried good looks soon became the toast of the Manmohan Singh Cabinet. Yet as he soon discovered, his portfolio as minister of state for external affairs was a much more sensitive assignment than the one he had left at the United Nations. Though the UPA soon became used to his tweets on official matters, Tharoor's latest tryst with

Ravi Shankar Prasad, "Tharoor's friend Sunanda has no relationship with Kerala or with cricket. It is obvious that the quid pro quo for this equity is the service rendered by Tharoor to the Kochi franchise." It's a charge that the Congress finds difficult to defend, more so as the minister had been flaunting the said Sunanda on his arm at various social occasions in the capital.

Suddenly the Tharoor saga turned from cricket to a case of probity in public life. Probity, as defined by conventional politicians quite unused to the so-called twit-terati. The fact that he made no attempts to hide his romantic liaisons from public scrutiny and the ease with which he tweeted his way into both the Capital's drawing

September 2009

Checked into a five-star hotel for three months, despite the austerity drive, claiming that he needed privacy. Was told to vacate the hotel and foot his bills.

September 2009

His Congress colleagues felt insulted by his flippant tweets such as the one on travelling by cattle class only "out of solidarity with all our holy cows".

December 2009

Criticised the government's new visa guidelines on Twitter after gaps were exposed in the visa system following the arrest of David Headley.

January 2010

Allegedly influenced the Ministry of External Affairs to purchase three of his books for distribution to all the 150 Indian missions abroad.

February 2010

Created a faux pas during the prime minister's visit to Saudi Arabia when he dubbed the country as a valuable "interlocutor" between India and Pakistan.

controversy has sent him tumbling down Raisina Hill. In a single stroke, he has managed to steal the headlines from the prime minister's much feted trip to Washington. It's a controversy that has even silenced the articulate Tharoor.

This time round, the MP from the Thiruvananthapuram constituency in Kerala is facing allegations about his own "external affairs" levelled by his once close buddy, IPL Chairman Lalit Modi. According to Modi, a close friend of the minister, Sunanda Pushkar, was given free equity allegedly worth Rs 75 crore for the Kochi IPL team that had Tharoor's blessings. Tharoor does not deny his role in "steering" the consortium, Rendezvous, towards Kerala and admits to knowing one of its members, Sunanda, "well". Yet he denies that he received any monetary returns for his "mentorship".

In politics, perception plays an important role. Quick to react, the BJP is already talking of a "quid pro quo" given to Sunanda on Tharoor's behalf. Says BJP spokesperson

rooms and 10 Janpath's indulgence baffled his Congress colleagues. With each controversy, they waited for the axe to drop but Tharoor carried on with not a hair out of place. Political Delhi is not used to the style of this flamboyant minister who doesn't conform to politics-as-usual. Despite being a first-time MP, he strode into Parliament without an iota of awe. As a junior minister, he does not worry about either hierarchy or protocol before airing his point of view, usually on twitter.

So, there is a certain glee amongst the party faithful who claim that this is "an individual matter and it is up to Tharoor to explain". The only Congressman who has spoken in Tharoor's defence is Union Minister C.P. Joshi who has his own axe to grind with Lalit Modi. The Congress President, Sonia Gandhi, is all too aware that Tharoor has become an even bigger political hot potato than the price rise. One that has united the BJP and the Left against the Congress and they are now demanding his